



LONG-ACTING REVERSIBLE CONTRACEPTION

What Is LARC?

Long-Acting Reversible Contraception (LARC) refers to highly effective methods of birth control that work for extended periods without requiring daily attention. LARC includes intrauterine devices (IUDs) and subdermal hormonal implants.

Types of LARC

- Hormonal IUDs (e.g., Mirena, Kyleena, Liletta, Skyla): A small T-shaped device inserted into the uterus that releases low doses of progestin. Effective for 3–8 years depending on the brand. Can reduce or stop periods.
- Copper IUD (e.g., Paragard): A non-hormonal option that uses copper ions to prevent fertilization. Effective for up to 10–12 years. Can also be used as emergency contraception if inserted within 5 days of unprotected intercourse.
- Hormonal implant (e.g., Nexplanon): A small flexible rod inserted under the skin of the upper arm that releases progestin. Effective for up to 3 years.

Effectiveness

LARCs are among the most effective reversible contraceptive methods available, with failure rates of less than 1% per year, which is comparable to permanent sterilization but fully reversible.

Advantages of LARC

- No daily, weekly, or monthly action required after insertion.
- Highly effective for the duration of use.
- Fertility returns quickly after removal.
- Cost-effective over time compared to monthly methods.
- Suitable for people who cannot use estrogen-containing contraceptives.

- Some options may reduce menstrual bleeding and pain.

Considerations and Side Effects

- Insertion may cause cramping and discomfort; should be performed by a trained provider.
- Copper IUD may increase menstrual bleeding and cramping, especially initially.
- Rare risks include expulsion or uterine perforation during insertion.
- Does not protect against STIs.
- Not appropriate for those with certain uterine abnormalities or unexplained vaginal bleeding.

Key Takeaway

LARC methods are among the most effective and convenient contraceptive options available. They are reversible, long-lasting, and appropriate for most people, including adolescents and those who have not had children.

Bloom provides educational guidance only. Always consult with a qualified healthcare professional for personalized medical advice.

Educational content informed by American College of Obstetricians and Gynecologists. (n.d.). Long-acting reversible contraception: IUDs and implants.

Secura, G. M., Allsworth, J. E., Madden, T., Mullersman, J. L., & Peipert, J. F. (2010). The Contraceptive CHOICE Project: Reducing barriers to long-acting reversible contraception. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention. (2020). U.S. medical eligibility criteria for contraceptive use.